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FAO Welcomes WTO Fisheries Subsidies Agreement to Curb Illegal Fishing, Promote Sustainability

FAO has welcomed the WTO Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies, calling it a crucial step to end harmful subsidies and protect marine resources. The pact bans support for illegal and overfished practices while boosting global cooperation for sustainable fisheries.

KJ Staff Updated 17 September, 2025 2:28 PM IST



The agreement bans subsidies that contribute to IUU fishing, affect overfished stocks, or support operations in high seas areas lacking proper regulation. (Photo Source: Canva)

Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO) has praised the implementation of the World Trade Organization’s (WTO) Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies, describing it as a significant step toward safeguarding global marine resources. This agreement aims to eliminate harmful subsidies that contribute to overfishing and illegal, unregulated, and unreported (IUU) fishing, while promoting the long-term sustainability of fisheries.



“This agreement is very positive for the sustainability of fisheries resources, which we all depend on. FAO looks forward to helping implement the agreement and achieve its potential,” said Manuel Barange, FAO Assistant Director-General and head of its Fisheries and [Aquaculture](#) Division. He stressed that fisheries are critical for food, nutrition and livelihoods, and warned that subsidizing damaging practices jeopardizes the future of the sector.

What is the primary goal of the WTO Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies?

☐ To privatize marine resources

☐ To eliminate harmful subsidies contributing to overfishing

☐ To increase fishing quotas globally

☐ To promote international trade tariffs

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The agreement bans subsidies that contribute to IUU fishing, affect overfished stocks, or support operations in high seas areas lacking proper regulation. FAO has backed WTO members with policy advice during negotiations and will now work with the WTO Fisheries Funding Mechanism to provide technical assistance and capacity-building, particularly for developing and least-developed nations.

Curbing IUU fishing has been a global priority, given its role in depleting fish stocks and weakening [food security](#). FAO’s Port State Measures Agreement (PSMA), in force since 2016 and ratified by 84 parties including the EU, already plays a key role in shutting ports to IUU fishing vessels and deterring illicit trade.

Barange also underlined the importance of greater regional cooperation, saying the new agreement will give fresh momentum to regional fisheries management bodies. Stronger collaboration, he noted, will be essential to ensure shared marine resources are used sustainably and equitably.

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